I believed that if we were ever going to break down the barriers of mistrust that divided our countries, we had to begin by establishing a personal relationship between the leaders of the two most powerful nations on earth.

During the previous five years, I had come to realize there were people in the Kremlin who had a genuine fear of the United States. I wanted to convince Gorbachev that we wanted peace and they had nothing to fear from us. So I had gone to Geneva with a plan.

The Russians were bringing their team of diplomats and arms control experts and we were bringing ours. But I wanted a chance to see Gorbachev alone.

Since Gorbachev had taken office eight months earlier, he and I had quietly exchanged a series of letters that had suggested to me he might be a different sort of Russian than the Soviet leaders we had known before.

That morning, as we shook hands and I looked into his smile, I sensed I had been right and felt a surge of optimism that my plan might work.

As we began our first meeting in the presence of our advisors, Gorbachev and I sat opposite one another. I had told my team what I was going to do.

As our technical experts began to speak, I said to him, “While our people here are discussing the need for arms control, why don’t you and I step outside and get some fresh air?”

Gorbachev was out of his chair before I could finish the sentence. We walked together about one hundred yards down a hill to a boathouse along the lakeshore.

As we descended the hill, the air was crisp and very cold. I’d asked members of the White House staff to light a fire in the boat-house before we got there and they had: Only later did I discover they’d built such a rip-roaring fire that it set an ornate wooden mantelpiece above the fireplace ablaze